



Calm finisher: In a final crackling with tension, Tilak Varma's composure outlasted the chaos as he guided India through a nervy chase of 147 against Pakistan. AFP

everyone watching, now people know about my potential," he laughed.

"Honestly, not many recognised my capabilities before that game. In that context, the innings was very significant. Now people say I can play according to the situation," he added. Asked whether expectations bring pressure, Tilak dismissed the thought. "Playing for the country is a golden opportunity. Even if you're a superstar, you must perform consistently. I can't take even a single game lightly. But I don't feel pressure — I've worked too hard for these chances. My goal is to seize them and finish matches."

For Tilak, mindset is everything. "If you have confidence, you can handle any challenge with ease. My attitude is the same whether it's club cricket, domestic matches, IPL or internationals. I love challenges and

thrive on them."

The coach who shaped him

If discipline is Tilak's hallmark, credit goes to his childhood coach and mentor, Salam Bayash, now Head Coach at Legala Cricket Academy in Hyderabad. "I owe everything to him. He believed in me from the start. I can never forget those long scooter rides to training every day," Tilak recalled.

"Salam bhai's dream is that I become the No. 1 player in the world and win the World Cup. He always told me that there will be ups and downs, but a player should never fall short of giving 100 per cent. Consistency is key and that's been my motto."

It was Tilak's consistent performances in domestic cricket that first caught the attention of IPL scouts. During the 2021–22 Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, he emerged as Hyderabad's second-highest run-scorer, amassing 215 runs in seven innings at a strike rate of 147.26.

His form made heads turn at the IPL 2022 auction, where Mumbai

Indians secured his services for Rs 1.70 crore — a move that proved instantly rewarding as Tilak slotted seamlessly into the side's core group.

Those IPL performances fast-tracked his rise to the international stage. Tilak made his T20I debut against West Indies in Tarouba in 2023, announcing himself in style as his first two scoring shots — off just his second and third deliveries — sailed for sixes.

Turning points and lessons

But it was against South Africa a year later that he truly bloomed — twin centuries crafted not in haste but with the quiet certainty of a young man beginning to understand his own powers. "Those hundreds came at the right time, under tough conditions. They gave me the belief that I was ready for the big stage. Now I even feel like a senior player in this format," he smiled.

Those knocks all but cemented Tilak's place in India's T20I setup as the natural successor to Kohli at No. 3. The opportunity came with a gesture of trust from skipper Suryakumar Yadav, who voluntarily